It was a haze. I remember reading *The Conscience of a Hacker* (aka *The Hacker's Manifesto*), Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash*, and reams of J. R. R. Tolkien, falling asleep midchapter and getting the characters and action confused, until I was dreaming that Gollum was by my bedside and whining, "Master, Master, information wants to be free."

While I was resigned to all the fever dreams sleep brought me, the thought of having to catch up on my schoolwork was the true nightmare. After I'd missed approximately four months of class, I got a letter in the mail from Arundel High informing me that I'd have to repeat my sophomore year. I'd say I was shocked, but the moment I read the letter, I realized that I'd known this was inevitable and had been dreading it for weeks. The prospect of returning to school, let alone of repeating two semesters, was unimaginable to me, and I was ready to do whatever it took to avoid it.

Just at the point when my glandular disease had developed into a full-on depression, receiving the school news shook me out of my slump. Suddenly I was upright and getting dressed in something other than pajamas. Suddenly I was online and on the phone, searching for the system's edges, searching for a hack. After a bit of research, and a lot of form-filling, my solution landed in the mailbox: I'd gotten myself accepted to college. Apparently, you don't need a high school diploma to apply.

Anne Arundel Community College was a local institution, certainly not as venerable as my sister's school, but it would do the trick. All that mattered was that it was accredited. I took the offer of admission to my high school administrators, who, with a curious and barely concealed mixture of resignation and glee, agreed to let me enroll. I'd attend college classes two days a week, which was just about the most that I could manage to stay upright and functional. By taking classes above my grade level, I wouldn't have to suffer through the year I'd missed. I'd just skip it.

AACC was about twenty-five minutes away, and the first few times I drove myself were perilous—I was a newly licensed driver who could barely stay awake at the wheel. I'd go to class and then come directly home to sleep. I was the youngest person in all my classes, and might even have been the youngest person at the school, alternately a mascot-like object of novelty and a discomfiting presence. This, along with the fact that I was still recovering, meant that I didn't hang out much. Also, because AACC was a commuter school, it had no active campus life. The anonymity of the school suited me fine, though, as did my classes, most of which were distinctly more interesting than anything I'd